

FreeCEN Newsletter – August 2026

Hello All

Welcome to the FreeCEN newsletter for August, and 26 new pieces have been added to the website over the last month, around 153,000 entries between these pieces. Details at the end of this newsletter.

These newsletters are sent on a monthly basis, and are usually sent out around the 4th of the month.

Do you have access to any census images? If so then you may be able to help FreeCEN. We have people to transcribe the census but we are short of image for a good number of localities.

FreeCEN can accept loans, or donations, or willing to buy (at reasonable prices) of scans, provided they originate from one of the following sources

- Archive CD Books
- Stepping Stones CD's/DVD's (some restrictions apply)
- Family History Society CD's/DVD's (must come with written permission to use)
- Microfiche/Microfilms (must come with written permission to use)

Only scans from one of the four sources listed above can be accepted.

Can you help us with this If so, do make contact with us and give us the details of what you do have.

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Contribution Guidelines

Contributions are welcome, and all received are considered. These should be emailed to [Chris Mahoney](mailto:chris.mahoney@freeukgenealogy.org.uk) (chris.mahoney@freeukgenealogy.org.uk).

They can be in any format, but I do have three particular requests with contributions.

1. Please do include a scanned image of the census record referred to (if appropriate) along with relevant source information (i.e. piece number, folio number, page number, and schedule number)
2. With any images, please include copies in their original format such as jpg or png (much easier to work with than copying one out of your article)
3. If you have quoted another source (or copied an image from somewhere), please quote what that source is

Previous FreeCEN Newsletters

Past editions of the newsletter are [now available to download](#) from the FreeCEN website. Or go to the “About” page, and then look on the right hand side under “See Also”.

The previous twelve are there now, all in downloadable PDF format (can also be read in some internet browsers). Older editions available on request.

Volunteer for FreeCEN

Like what you see in these newsletters? Has our website helped you with your family research? Then please consider helping to expand our database. We have plenty of coordinators who would welcome you as a member of their team.

You need only basic computer skills and you can use any spreadsheet app. We provide plenty of help and support. We also supply the scans.

Use this link to the [Volunteer page](#) or select “Volunteer” in the purple menu bar near the top of any page on the website.

News from Denise Colbert (Q2 April to June 2026)

(Chief Operating Officer, Free UK Genealogy CIO)

Hello everyone

In my last update, I wrote about the strong foundations we were putting in place across Free UK Genealogy. Much of that work was about preparing for the future: growing new projects, strengthening our volunteer community and turning ideas from the Strategy Weekend into practical action.

Three months on, it's been encouraging to see those foundations starting to bear fruit. We've reached some significant milestones, welcomed new volunteers into the organisation, and continued improving the projects that so many of you contribute to every day.

FreePRO has welcomed more volunteers, bringing expertise in areas including user experience, software development, testing and project support. Work on digitising the probate calendars has continued, alongside improvements to the tools and workflows that will support volunteers as the project grows.

FreeBMD2 has also continued to develop steadily. Since its launch, the team has been working through feedback from volunteers and users, making improvements to searching, accessibility and the ways people can report problems or suggest corrections. It's been particularly encouraging to see how much thoughtful feedback has come from our own volunteers, helping shape the site as it continues to mature.

The biggest single achievement this quarter comes from FreeCEN.

For several years, volunteers have been working to convert older FreeCEN1 VLD files into the newer CSV format used by FreeCEN2. It has been one of those long-running pieces of work that quietly underpins everything else, and I'm delighted to say that the final inter-county conversions have now been completed.

It's a wonderful example of what persistence can achieve. Hundreds of thousands of records have been brought into a stronger, more sustainable format, leaving FreeCEN in a much better position for future development.

The team has also continued improving searching, accessibility and support for a wider range of names and places, while thinking carefully about how we can make even more records available. One area we'll be encouraging volunteers to consider is proofreading. Many records have already been transcribed and are simply waiting for that final stage before they can be published, so proofreading is one of the most direct ways volunteers can help unlock new material for researchers. If helping us clear our proofreading backlog and make more records available to researchers sounds like something you'd enjoy, please speak to your Coordinator. They'd be delighted to tell you more.

FreeREG has also had a positive few months. FreeComETT-REG has its creator, Hilary, back on board helping the team regain momentum after a challenging period, and FreeREG has continued to make progress with a new cohort of software volunteers learning the ropes by clearing off some 'good first issues' from the backlog.

Across all of our projects, there have also been dozens of smaller improvements that may never make headlines but collectively make a real difference: refining search behaviour, improving accessibility, responding to user feedback, fixing bugs and making our websites easier to use. Those incremental improvements are every bit as important as the bigger milestones.

One of the most encouraging things this quarter has been seeing new volunteers join Free UK Genealogy.

Since my last update, Scott Paget has stepped down from his Programme Manager role. We're very grateful for the work Scott did to bring more structure to our newer projects. Stephen Coward has now taken on this role, and has already made a real difference, recruiting several volunteer Project Managers and helping us strengthen support across our projects.

We've welcomed volunteers into software development, communications, recruitment, project support and several other areas of the organisation.

Every new volunteer brings something different, and I'm very grateful to everyone who has given their time to help new arrivals settle in and feel part of the team.

So much recruitment has also prompted us to think more carefully about the volunteer journey. How do we make it easier for someone to find a role they'll enjoy? How do we support them as they learn? How do we help them grow if they decide they'd like to take on something new?

One conversation in the recent FreeCEN Coordinator meeting really stands out. Geoff was reflecting on Cheryl's journey to becoming a County Coordinator, and how that had happened gradually through encouragement and shared experience rather than by expecting someone to take on everything at once. I suspect many of us could tell a similar story. Free UK Genealogy has always been full of volunteers who are willing to help one another, and I hope that's something we'll continue to build on.

Over the next few days we'll be advertising for a new trustee, and this time we're particularly hoping to hear from people within our own volunteer community. Nobody understands our organisation better than the people who give their time to it every week, and we'd love to see more volunteers helping shape Free UK Genealogy at Board level.

The role will appear shortly on our Reach Volunteering page:
<https://reachvolunteering.org.uk/org/free-uk-genealogy>

We'll send the direct link around as soon as the advert is live. If you've ever wondered whether becoming a trustee might be for you, I do encourage you to have a look. Please don't rule yourself out because you haven't been a trustee before. Experience can be learned. Enthusiasm for our mission and sound judgement matter just as much.

The planned UK Genealogy Charity Summit took place in April at the Society of Genealogists HQ in London. Although every organisation around the table had its own priorities, it quickly became clear that many of us are wrestling with the same questions: how to recruit and support volunteers, improve access to records and ensure that family history remains freely available for future generations.

There was a genuine willingness to keep talking, share ideas and support one another. We've already started following up on some of those conversations, and I hope they'll lead to closer collaboration across the sector over the coming months.

As we move into the second half of the year, we'll continue improving our websites, supporting our projects and, most importantly, supporting the volunteers who make them possible.

One of the things that's become increasingly clear to me this year is that our greatest strength is the community of people behind them. Every improvement we make, every new record we publish and every new project we begin ultimately comes back to volunteers generously sharing their time and knowledge with others.

Thank you for everything you've contributed over the past three months. I look forward to updating you again in the autumn.

With best wishes,

Denise Colbert

Chief Operating Officer
Free UK Genealogy CIO

Pieces Incorporated during July 2026

(Incorporated pieces are those that have been transcribed, proofread, and are now part of the online searchable database)

County	Year	Piece	Location	Civil Parishes	Number of Entries
Anglesey	1881	RG11_5585	Llangefni	Llanallgo, Llanbedrgoch, Llanddyfnan, Llaneugrad, Llanfair Mathafarn Eithaf, Llanfihangel Trer Beirdd	2,689
Anglesey	1881	RG11_5586	Llangefni	Llangefni, Llangwyllog, Penrhosllugwy, Tregaian	2,281
Anglesey	1881	RG11_5587	Bryngwran	Aberffraw, Bodwrog, Ceirchiog, Cerrigceinwen, Heneglwys, Llanbeulan	2,621
Anglesey	1881	RG11_5588	Bryngwran	Gwyndy, Llandrygarn, Llanfaelog, Llangwyfan, Llechylched, Trewalchmai	2,568
Berkshire	1891	RG12_973	Lambourn	East Garston, East Shefford, Eastbury, Lambourn, West Shefford	3,313

Cambridgeshire	1841	HO107_63	Armingford	Abington in the Clay or Abington Pigotts, Bassingbourn (Kneesworth), Croydon cum Clopton, East Hatley, Guilden Morden(Manor of Odsey), Littlington, Melbourn, Meldreth, Royston, Shingay, Steeple Morden, Tadlow, Wendy, Whaddon	8,649
Cambridgeshire	1881	RG11_1673	Balsham	Balsham, Carlton cum Willingham, Horseheath, West Wickham, West Wratting, Weston Colville	3,557
Durham	1891	RG12_4052	Stockton	Stockton on Tees	7,775
Essex	1851	HO107_1769A	Walthamstow	Leyton, Walthamstow, Wanstead, Woodford(Woodford Bridge)	4,809
Essex	1891	RG12_1313	Stratford	Forest Gate, Stratford, West Ham	7,022
Glamorganshire	1871	RG10_5416	Cowbridge	Cowbridge, Gileston, Llanblethian, St Athan	2,362
Glamorganshire	1891	RG12_4486	Llansamlet	Llansamlet Higher	5,012
Gloucestershire	1851	HO107_1951	Bristol St Augustine	St Augustine the Less, (Brandon Hill), St Michael	14,434
Gloucestershire	1881	RG11_2558	Fairford	Dunfield, Hatherop, Kempsford, Maisey Hampton, Marston Maisey, Poulton, Quenington	2,572
Gloucestershire	1881	RG11_2559	Bibury	Ablington, Aldsworth, Arlington, Bibury, Coln St Aldwins, Eastington, Eastleach Martin, Eastleach Turville, Farmington, Fyfield, Little Barrington, Northleach, Sherborne, Southrop, Windrush	4,951
Huntingdonshire	1861	RG9_976	Warboys	Broughton, Bury, Old Hurst, Warboys, Wistow	3,384
Leicestershire	1841	HO107_604B	Borough	St Margaret	34,165

Lincolnshire	1851	HO107_2105	Lincoln Home	Boultham, Bracebridge, Burton, Canwick, Castle Dykings, Cherry Willingham, Fiskerton, Greetwell, Lincoln, Lincoln Castle Prison, Lincoln County Lunatic Asylum, Lincoln St Benedict, Lincoln St Botolph, Lincoln St John in Newport, Lincoln St Margaret in the Close, Lincoln St Mark, Lincoln St Martin, Lincoln St Mary Magdalen in the Bail, Lincoln St Mary le Wigford, Lincoln St Nicholas in Newport, Lincoln St Paul, Lincoln St Peter at Arches, Lincoln St Peter at Gowts, Lincoln St Peter in Eastgate (Cold Bath House), Lincoln St Swithin, Nettleham, North Carlton, Reepham, Riseholme, South Carlton, Stamford St Michael	2,026
Lincolnshire	1851	HO107_2108	Tetford	Asgarby, Ashby Puerorum (Stainsby), Bag Enderby, Belchford, Claxby Pluckacre, Dalderby, Fulletby, Greetham, Hagworthingham, Hameringham, High Toynton, Holbeck, Low Toynton, Lusby, Mareham on the Hill, Miningsby, Moorby, Salmonby, Scrafield, Scrivelsby, Somersby, Tetford, Winceby, Wood Enderby	4,594
Monmouthshire	1891	RG12_4362	Pontypool	Abersychan, Pontnewydd, Trevethin with Pontypool	8,103
Norfolk	1841	HO107_764	Eynsford	Great Witchingham, Little Witchingham, Lyng (Lyng-Easthaugh), Morton on the Hill, Reepham, Ringland, Sall, Sparham, Swannington, Themelthorpe, Thurning, Twyford, Weston Longville, Whitwell, Wood Dalling, Wood Norton	5,367

Pembrokeshire	1861	RG9_4169	St Davids	Ramsey Island, St Davids, St Davids Cylch Y Dre, St Edrins, St Elvis, St Lawrence, Whitchurch	2,557
Pembrokeshire	1861	RG9_4172	Fishguard	Little Newcastle, Llanychaer, Manorowen, Morvil, Pontfaen, Puncheston, Spittal, St Nicholas, Walton East	2,051
Suffolk	1841	HO107_1017	Blything	Ubbeston, Uggeshall, Walberswick, Walpole, Wangford (Henham), Wenhaston (Mells), Westhall, Westleton, Wissett, Wrentham, Yoxford	7,434
Suffolk	1841	HO107_1033	Risbridge	Great Thurlow, Great Wrating, Lidgate, Little Thurlow, Little Wrating, Moulton, Ousden, Poslingford, Stansfield, Stoke by Clare, Stradishall, Whixoe, Wickhambrook, Withersfield	7,170
Worcestershire	1891	RG12_2052A	Ledbury	Mathon	1,231

FreeCEN1

The last reported update to our old website at [FreeCEN1](#) took place on July 6th 2021. Further updates to this website have been discontinued, and any new uploads of completed pieces will take place on FreeCEN2 only.

We expect that the old website will be taken off-line at some point.